What Happens in the Shahnameh After Dark?

Monsters, secrets, and sneak attacks!

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Happy belated Halloween!

This year I dressed up as Percy Jackson, and my little sister (aka Gordafarid) was the Princess in Black! If you don't know, the Princess in Black is an undercover princess who fights monsters. So we were both monster-fighting heroes... just from different books!

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Percy Jackson and the Princess in Black... ready for monsters!

We went to a fun Halloween block party at night with a really spooky haunted mansion and some 20-foot-tall monsters! It was CRAZY! But it

got me thinking... there are lots of Divs and other scary creatures in the *Shahnameh*, but have you ever noticed how many important things happen at night?

I started reading the stories again and remembered that the *Shahnameh* heroes have some pretty crazy adventures while the rest of us are sleeping... and not all of them include monsters!

The Worst Time to Fall Asleep

Remember how in my last post I talked about Rakhsh saving Rostam from a lion and a dragon? Well, both of those things happened at night!

First, Rostam falls asleep and a lion shows up. Luckily, Rakhsh kills the lion before it can attack. Then another night, Rostam falls asleep again, and a giant dragon appears. Rakhsh has to wake him up THREE times before Rostam finally sees it!

I'm starting to think Rostam needs to be more careful about when he naps! HA!

The Night That Changed Everything

But not everything that happens at night involves scary creatures or monsters. Sometimes just one night can change someone's whole life.

For example, when Rostam is staying in Samangan, Princess Tahmineh secretly visits him one night. She tells him that she's heard about his adventures and wants to have a child with him. That child grows up to be Sohrab!

If you've read my other posts, you probably know what happens to Sohrab. When Sohrab grows up, he fights Rostam, who has no idea he's fighting his own son! Rostam ends up mortally wounding Sohrab before figuring out the truth. But by then, it's too late to save him.

That whole tragedy started with just one meeting on a random night! I bet Rostam and Tahmineh never imagined what that night would mean.

The Abandoned Hero

Here's another story that has nothing to do with monsters.

When a hero named Sam had a son named Zal, he panicked because the baby was born with completely white hair and skin! Not because he was old, obviously... he was a baby! But Sam thought his baby's appearance was a terrible sign, and he was so ashamed that he ordered Zal to be abandoned in the mountains in the middle of the night. Imagine being abandoned just because your hair or skin was a different color!

Luckily, a giant magical bird named the Simorgh found Zal and raised him. And Zal eventually grew up to become Rostam's dad. So if the Simorgh hadn't rescued Zal, Rostam probably would never have existed!

I think it's funny that Sam had no idea his son would grow up to become someone so important!

Sneak Attack!

Nighttime is apparently also a good time to attack your enemies. At least that's what Afrasiyab, the king of Turan, thought!

During one of the wars between Iran and Turan, Afrasiyab launches a surprise attack on the Iranian army at night. The soldiers aren't expecting it, and many of them are killed before they can defend themselves. There's actually a Persian word for this kind of sneak attack: *shabkhun*, or night raid.

I guess that's one way to win a battle, but it doesn't seem too honorable to attack people when they're sleeping! But the *Shahnameh* has lots of characters who don't always fight fairly!

So Why Does So Much Happen at Night?

At first, I thought nighttime in the *Shahnameh* was just about scary things. You know... lions, dragons, and sneak attacks. But now I'm wondering if there's something else going on...

Why do so many important things happen when the heroes can't see clearly?

Rostam can't see the lion or dragon coming because he's asleep. Rostam and Tahmineh have no idea that one night will lead to such a terrible tragedy. Sam can't see what kind of person his son will be. And the Iranian soldiers can't see Afrasiyab's army coming in the dark.

That's one reason I think these stories are so interesting. Even the greatest heroes don't always know what will happen next!

What do you think is scarier... monsters or not knowing what will happen next?

Thanks for reading. See you next time!

Jack

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